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Esotericisms of the Twentieth Century

I. Gnosés in the Wake of the Western “Tradition”

1. “Traditional Sciences,” Christian Theosophy, and New Forms of *Gnosis*

Surviving in the form of activities as much speculative as operative, practiced inside initiatic associations or by individuals, the so-called “traditional” sciences (i.e., especially astrology, alchemy, and “magic”) directly touched a broad public. The most popular is evidently astrology, “queen” of the divinatory Arts. What big bookstore does not dedicate entire bookshelves to it, taking over most of the “esoteric” or “occult” section? What media does not have its column of daily or weekly advice? In its most widespread aspect—simplistic predictions, flat utilitarianism—it answers the more or less conscious need to rediscover in our world, which many consider too uncentered and fragmented, the *Unus mundus*, the unity of the universe and of humanity, through a language founded on the principle of universal correspondences. When this need leads to a concept of astrology that does not reduce it to a mere “mancy” (just an instrument of divination), but that induces the practice of a form of hermeneutics of “signs,” then we can see in it a form of *gnosis* that connects it with esoteric currents properly speaking. After Alan Leo ([chapter 4](#), section II, 3), many in the twentieth century, from Karl Brandler-Pracht (1864–1945) to André Barbault, including Daniel Chénnevière (alias Dane Rudhyar, 1895–1985), have considered it as such and contributed, more or less successfully, to confer on it a status in its own right in the humanities.

Since Alliette ([chapters 1–3](#)), the Tarot has become another esoteric current in its own right, composed of an ever-increasing referential corpus. The Tarot serves not only to tell fortunes, but also to practice a form of *gnosis* drawing from other traditions, like Kabbalah—thus, with Aleister Crowley (*The Book of*

Thoth, 1944; section III, 1; [chapter 4](#), section III, 1). Among other exegetes of the Tarot, let us cite Marc Haven (*Le Tarot*, 1937), Gérard Van Rijnberk (*Le Tarot*, 1946), Paul Marteau (*Le Tarot de Marseille*, 1949), and Valentin Tomberg (*Meditationen*, 1972; *infra*, 2).

As in the past, the alchemical domain is divided between the “blowers” (*souffleurs*, a French epithet for alchemists whose goal is almost solely for material gain) and the “Philosophers” (those who pursue a spiritual goal, in addition to being “operative”). Some of these occasionally have organizations, like the Paracelsus Research Society, in Salt Lake City, Utah, and then in Australia, directed by Albert Richard Riedel (*alias* Frater Albertus, 1911–1984). Likewise, the Soluna laboratories, in Bavaria, were created by a notable neo-Paracelsian alchemist, Alexander von Bernus (1880–1965), who also was the author of a relatively abundant work in the tradition of German Romanticism. Outside of such associations, alchemical practice rather preserved the character of a private religion that it always has the tendency to assume.

Rare are the “Philosophers” of the twentieth century having left interesting written work. This explains in part the success of those who produced one, such as Eugène Léon Canseliet (1899–1982), whose reputation also owes much to the mystery surrounding his master Fulcanelli. This master, whose biography remains unknown, has left a *Mystère des cathédrales* (1926; *The Mystery of the Cathedrals*) as well as *Les Demeures philosophales* (1930; *The Dwellings of the Philosophers*, 1999). His disciple Canseliet has authored a few various works, among which were *Deux logis alchimiques* (1945) and *Alchimie* (1964). Both were as concerned with detecting the “alchemical signatures” on the stones of certain buildings as with seeking the Philosopher’s Stone.

Other authors involved with this “science” dealt with its spiritual or initiatic aspects without necessarily being working practitioners (thus Julius Evola, *La Tradizione ermetica*, 1931; section II, 1). Alchemy has continued to occupy a good place in contemporary Western culture. Reprints and facsimile reproductions (texts and images) became easily available especially in the 1970s and 1980s.

Furthermore, many historians have written about it (section III, 2). “Magic” belongs to the esoteric currents of the twentieth century insofar as it is viewed as not just a practice to procure material gratifications. On this understanding, we find it spread especially within societies and various groupings. The historian Massimo Introvigne (section III, 3) has put forward a distinction, debatable but convenient, between two categories: ceremonial magic and initiatic magic. The first would emphasize knowledge and/or powers, the effectiveness of rites. The second would stress the legitimacy of initiatic filiation, the condition of an “authentic” transformation of the member elect. Both “magics” were practiced in the hothouses of secret societies, of which several produced a rather abundant literature (this was the case of several of the works cited in this [chapter 5](#)). As for the first category, one of its most famous

representatives was Aleister Crowley, already mentioned regarding the occultist current (section III, 2; [chapter 4](#), section III, 1) and whose work and “initiatric” activities were manifold (*The Equinox of the Gods*, 1936) until the 1940s (section III, 1).

If the current of Christian Kabbalah had since long run dry, Jewish Kabbalah and, notably, the Sephirotic tree continued nonetheless to inspire many researchers in quest of a key to *gnosis*, but often by cutting them from the original Hebraic cultural terrain; (Ramon Llull and Giordano Bruno had already done the same). It is tempting, indeed, to use this tree as a support of meditation, a tool of thought. Taking this approach was Raymond Abellio (1907–1986; section III, 1; *La Bible, document chiffré*, 1950; *La Fin de l'ésotérisme*, 1973). In fact, for minds not rooted in the Jewish tradition, the corpus of Greek and Latin references lends itself more easily to a hermeneutic of a spiritual order. For that matter, the neo-Alexandrian current ([chapter 4](#), section III, 1, 3) did not run dry in the twentieth century, as persistent interest in the *Corpus Hermeticum* bears testimony, notably several new editions completed by exegetic commentaries (of a neo-Rosicrucian character, in particular). Among these are the publications of the Shrine of Wisdom in 1923, the book by Duncan Greenless (*The Gospel of Hermes*, 1949), and that by Jan van Rijckenborgh (*De Egyptische oergnosis*, 1960–1965; section II, 2).

2. Presence of Christian Theosophy

The main representatives of a properly Christian theosophy were mostly German, Russian, and French. Rudolf Steiner continued his personal work (*Mein Lebensgang*, autobiography published in 1925; study on the *Chymische Hochzeit of Andreae*, 1917–1918), marked less by this current properly speaking than by certain aspects of the *Naturphilosophie* of the preceding century. The influence of Leopold Ziegler (1881–1958; *Ueberlieferung and Menschwerdung*, 1948; *Gestaltwandel der Götter*, 1922) was more subtle. This sage residing on the shores of Lake Constance shared with René Guénon (section II, 1) the idea of a primordial Tradition that was fragmented, eclipsed, and forgotten. If he scrutinized myths and studied religions, however, it was more as a disciple of Boehme and of Baader, as a theosopher attentive to the symbolism of the phases of alchemical transmutation. Thus he placed Sophia at the very heart of his *gnosis*, associating her with a philosophy of Nature inseparable from a philosophy of History—itself conceived as a whole, as much biological as spiritual.

The Orthodox Church, which dedicated to Sophia the celebrated Cathedrals of Saint Sophia in Constantinople and Kiev, generally made this personage a real, central figure, contrary to what happened in Western Christianity, where she was never very present except in the Christian theosophical current. However, Sophia being one theme among others in the repertory of great images, the fact of integrating her into a theology does not necessarily imply that one is “theosophizing.” This remark obtains

regarding Father Paul Florensky (*La Colonne et le fondement de la vérité*, 1914 [*The Pillar and Ground of the Truth*, 2004]), and Father Sergei Bulgakov (*La Sagesse de Dieu*, 1936 [*Sophia: the Wisdom of God*, 1993], *Du verbe incarné*, 1943; *Le Paraclet*, 1946). Inspired not only by Vladimir Solovyov but also by Florensky, Tommaso Palamidessi founded an initiatic Order in Turin in 1948, Loto + Croce, which became the Associazione Archeosofica in 1968. Closer to Germanic theosophy than Florensky or Bulgakov, we find Nicholas Berdiaev (1874–1948; *Le Sens de la création*, 1916 [*The Meaning of the Creative Act*, 1955 [1916 in Russian]; *Études sur Jacob Boehme*, 1930; *Spirit and Reality*, 1957 [1946 in Russian]), a Russian philosopher established in France. Berdiaev, a great admirer of Boehme (whom he considered “a summit of the visionary power of humanity”) and of Baader, proved critical with regard to what he called “occultism.” On the latter, he wrote, in *The Meaning of the Creative Act*, “the great meaning” is nevertheless “to be already turned toward the cosmic secret and toward humanity's part in it.” In the same movement, he sharply criticized the teachings of the Theosophical Society and those of Rudolf Steiner because of the evolutionism that is part of their system, and saw in them “a serious symptom of the decomposition of the physical plane of Being” (*The Meaning of Creation*).

If Christian theosophy was but one aspect among others of the Berdiaevian work, on the other hand almost the entire voluminous book of Boris Mouravieff (1961–1965), *Gnôsis. Étude et commentaire sur la tradition ésotérique de l'orthodoxie orientale*, stood within the pale of esotericism. It is a big compendium of “psychosophy” (as he calls it) and of a Christian anthroposophy, partly Steinerian in character, that this independent thinker, also somewhat influenced by Gurdjieff, presents us in the form of instructions meant for the reader's illumination and inner transformation. All the same, the references to the Western corpus are rare in it. The Centre d'Études Chrétiennes Ésotériques created in 1961 by Mouravieff has enjoyed a certain success.

One of the most remarkable books of the twentieth century among all those mentioned in this chapter is *Méditations sur les 22 Arcanes majeurs du tarot*, written in French; published anonymously, first in German in 1972, then in several other languages (*Meditations on the Tarot: A Journey into Christian Hermeticism*, 1985). The author, Valentin Tomberg (1901–1973), a Russian of Baltic German origin, was a professor of law. He was a member of the Anthroposophical Society for a few years, but broke from it and spent the last years of his life in London where he wrote this work. There may not be a better introduction to Christian theosophy and to any philosophical reflection on Western esoteric currents. Let us note that despite the title, it is hardly a treatise on the Tarot (the author uses the Arcana only as a point of departure, a support, for “meditation”).

In France, Auguste-Edouard Chauvet, a continuator of Fabre d'Olivet and of Saint-Yves d'Alveydre ([chapter 4](#), section II, 3), scrutinized the book of Moses, taking support from his two predecessors, but

enriched their contribution with new perspectives; his *Ésotérisme de la Genèse* (1946–1948) was one of the most interesting works of Christian theosophy in the twentieth century. Robert Amadou, who considered himself the disciple of Chauvet, was his commentator and appeared as a Christian theosopher (*Occident, Orient: parcours d'une tradition*, 1987; and cf. *supra*, [introduction](#), section III).

The work of the Islamologist Henry Corbin dealt primarily with the theosophies of Islam, but occasionally with Christian theosophy, marshalled in the context of the three great monotheisms.

Translator and commentator of Iranian and Islamic philosophical texts, this university scholar attempted to ally scientific rigor with personal commitment to a theosophy whose Christian component takes on, in his work, a distinctly docetist hue. Making a plea for the constitution of a “comparative esotericism of the Religions of the Book,” he sought to bring out the relationships that would connect some Christian theosophers (like Swedenborg and Oetinger) with their Shi'ite Islamic counterparts (cf. e.g., “Herméneutique spirituelle comparée,” in *Eranos Jahrbuch*, no. 33, 1965). In the work of this exegete, Sophia and the angelic world occupy an important position. Prominent too is what he called the *mundus imaginalis*—the imaginal world—or mesocosm, an intermediary world situated between the perceptible world and the “intelligible” or divine world, a *mundus* “where spirits become corporealized and bodies become spiritualized.”

3. Gnosis and Science: Toward a New Pansophy?

The occultist current had shown itself powerless to stimulate the emergence of a new Nature philosophy comparable to the *Naturphilosophie* of the period of German Romanticism. The twentieth century did not really witness a resurgence of this type, despite the work of certain authors already encountered here, such as Rudolf Steiner, Frater Albertus, and Alexander von Bernus (section I, 3), who stood to some extent within this kind of tradition.

It is nevertheless appropriate to make a special place for Gurdjieff and for Ouspensky. The Greco-Armenian George Ivanovitch Gurdjieff (1877–1949; section II, 3), like Boehme but without connecting to theosophy of a Christian type, posited the existence of two Natures. One is “creatural”; the other is “eternal,” a duality concretely manifested by the appearance of a great many levels of materiality within a network of universal interdependence. Structured according to an original arithmology, this cosmology, or this cosmosophy, is rich and complex. In *In Search of the Miraculous: Fragments of an Unknown Teaching* (1949), the Russian Piotr Dem'ianovich Ouspensky (section II, 3) explicated this philosophy of Gurdjieff, of which we also find elements in the book by the latter, *Beelzebub's Tales to*

his *Grandson* (published in 1950). Ouspensky appeared furthermore in a good position beside Gurdjieff as a philosopher of Nature, by his book *A New Model of the Universe* (1930–1931, as well as *Tertium Organon*, 1920–1922, already cited in relation to Gurdjieff, [chapter 4](#), section II, 3).

In the course of the last decades, new reflections were put forward, bearing on this idea of Nature philosophy understood in a light of *gnosis*. This was the case of thinkers such as, first, the perennialist Seyyed Hosseyn Nasr (*Man and Nature*, 1968; section II, 2) and second, the microphysicist Basarab Nicolescu (*Nous, la particule et le monde*, 1985; and this evocative title: *La science, le sens et l'évolution: essai sur J. Böhme*, 1988 [*Science, Meaning and Evolution: The Cosmology of Jacob Boehme*, 1991]). A third example is the philosopher Michel Cazenave (*La Science et l'Âme de Monde*, 1983). At this juncture, mention must be made of a great mind of our times, Raymond Abellio (1907–1986; section I, 1; III, 1), a graduate of the École Polytechnique. Highly educated in both the “hard sciences” and the humanities, this philosopher has authored many writings on Kabbalah, on astrology and on the Tarot. However, he is mostly renowned for having elaborated an “absolute structure” (cf. *La Structure absolue*, 1965) founded on the idea of “universal interdependence” and whose practical application is meant to lead to a form of *gnosis* both experiential and intellectual.

In the fields of physics, astrophysics, and life sciences, an increasing number of thinkers emerged, proposing models of the universe, suggesting hypotheses of meaning. The problem of the origins of the cosmos and that of the relationships between Spirit and Nature, were—and continue to be—the subject of passionate and impassioned debates. These take the form of many conferences and symposia (of the type “Science and Tradition,” “Religion and Science,” etc.), in which the names of the representatives of the esoteric currents of the past are sometimes convoked. These debates, however, nearly always result in considerations privileging the “hard sciences,” even while claiming to rejoice in seeing the emergence of new paradigms that would free scientific research from the ghetto to which scienticism had confined it for many decades. From an esoteric perspective, such debates, at their best, tend to produce forms of *neo-gnosis* very different from those that had previously flourished (to wit, *La Gnose de Princeton* [1974] of Raymond Ruyer, *The Tao of Physics* [1975] of Fritjof Capra, or *L'Esprit cet inconnu* [1977] of Jean Charon). Indeed, what differentiates such *neo-gnosis* from most *gnostic* constructions presented in the earlier chapters is that the former borrow from the latter only some of their “exterior” characteristics, thus failing to be based on a “myth of origins.” According to these former constructions, a spiritually conducted hermeneutic would be capable of approaching such a myth on a variety of levels of reality.

II. At the Crossroads of “Tradition”

1. René Guénon

To counteract the multiplicity of initiatic Orders connected with the occultist current and the aspects of the latter that he deemed doubtful, the Frenchman René Guénon (1886–1951) undertook a work of reformation placed under the sign of “Tradition.” He knew these Orders well for having been a member of several of them in his youth. He had even flirted with spiritualism around 1908. In 1914, he took initiation into the Grand Lodge of France. Within the Gnostic Church ([chapter 4](#), section III, 1), he frequented men (Léon Champrenaud and Albert de Pouvoirville) whose influence on him, added to that of the Orientals whom he met in 1908 and 1909, determined his vocation as a reformer.

In 1921, he published *Introduction générale à l'étude des doctrines hindoues* (*Introduction to the Study of the Hindu Doctrines*)¹ in which the essence of his metaphysics is already expounded. In *Le Théosophisme. Histoire d'une pseudo-religion* (*Theosophy, the History of a Pseudo-Religion*), published the same year and directed against the Theosophical Society (TS), he demonstrated his biting, polemical turn of mind, which also animated *L'Erreur spirite* (1923 [*The Spiritist Fallacy*]), another poisoned arrow, shot this time against Spiritualism. Almost all his subsequent works reveal this will to cleanse, to purify, which bears not only on the Western esoteric currents (especially the occultist one), but just as much on most Western philosophies (*Orient and Occident*, 1924 [*East and West*]).

In 1927, in *Le Roi du Monde* (*King of the World*) he affirmed the existence of a spiritual center or “geometric space,” guarantor of the orthodoxy of the different traditions. In *La Crise du Monde moderne* (1927 [*The Crisis of the Modern World*]), he compares the Hindu vision of the cosmic cycles with our current civilization, identifying the latter with the so-called era of the *Kali Yuga*, a dark age of degeneration coming at the end of one of the “great cycles” or *manvantaras*. In 1930, Guénon traveled to Egypt where he remained until his death, occurring at his home in Cairo. There he wrote *Le Symbolisme de la Croix* (1931 [*The Symbolism of the Cross*]), *Les États multiples de l'Être* (1932 [*The Multiple States of the Being*]), *Le Règne de la quantité et les signes des temps* (1945 [*The Reign of Quantity and the Signs of the Times*]), and *La Grande Triade* (1946 [*The Great Triad*]). His abundant bibliography is not limited to these titles. He has always proved furthermore, to be a prolific author of articles, an indefatigable correspondent, and a polemicist with an acid pen.

Guénon claimed to possess a complex metaphysical doctrine of Hindu origin bearing on the Non-Being (Brahma, the Absolute) and the Being—His manifestation—with “multiple states,” to which human beings are connected. This metaphysics is absent from the Western esoteric currents. Guénon nevertheless occupies an important place in their history, for four main reasons. The first is his numerous public stands: he attracted much attention by making strong pronouncements. The second is the insistence with which he affirmed the existence of a “primordial Tradition” situated beyond all these

currents and all the traditions and religions of the world. Guénon received the heritage of this notion from the Renaissance (*philosophia perennis*), from Romanticism, and from the TS, but he hypostasized it more than anyone else hitherto had done. Furthermore, he insisted on the need for authentic initiatic filiation in the attempt to gain access to this “Tradition,” an insistence well adapted to inciting the members of many existing initiatic societies to question this Tradition’s value. Third, he produced many writings on symbolism, an area of predilection for anyone who feels at home with various forms of “esotericism”—even if the manner in which he theorizes the notion of “symbol” can leave demanding readers dissatisfied. Fourth, his writing style is remarkably clear and convincing, in harmony with the vigor of the purpose (even though the latter lacks historical rigor); this partly accounts for the influence he has been exerting from the 1920s until today in various milieux—philosophical, literary, and artistic. To oppose the proliferation of initiations of his time, which he considered false for the most part, Guénon proposed the initiatic regularity of Freemasonry and of the Catholic Church. However, this regularity is only a temporary channel; Christianity itself must be transcended, because any religion is only a form, a limiting aspect of the “supreme intellectuality,” an avatar of the primordial Tradition. Guénon represents an impressive voice of intellectual asceticism. No one more than he has striven to put us on guard against the confusion between the “mental” and the “spiritual,” and against sentimentality in matters of spirituality. “Esotericism,” or better “esoterism” (cf. introduction, section I), often takes, in Guénon, the meaning of “metaphysical principles,” whereas “exotericism” covers everything that relates to the “individual.”

It remains, nevertheless, that this “Descartes of esotericism,” whose power of synthesis we can only admire, blithely threw the baby out with the bathwater. While rejecting Western philosophy, he seemed to know precious little about Christian theosophy (the Germanic world was alien to him). By mistrust of the adulterated, he preserved nothing, or nearly, of the hermetic-alchemical Western tradition and located at the Renaissance the great divorce from metaphysics. Through ignorance of the epistemological breakthroughs of his time, he had a false—because outdated—idea of science (indeed, he was neither a scientist nor a full-fledged historian). He rejected this science, just as he condemned modernity in all its aspects—and loftily ignored Nature. The “world of manifestation”—the palpable world—as he liked to say, has even less reality than our shadow projected on a wall. Because of their lack of interest in Nature and most Western esoteric traditions, within the history of the latter, “Guénonism,” and perennialism in general, constitute a new phenomenon.

2. The Perennialist Current

Perennialism (from the Latin *philosophia perennis*) serves to designate (see also introduction, section I) a religious philosophy that emphasizes the notion of primordial Tradition, mother of all the others and understood in a Guénonian sense. If Guénon is, in some way, its leader, his principal “successor” was Frithjof Schuon (1907–1999; *De l'Unité transcendante des religions*, 1948 [*The Transcendent Unity of Religion*, 1953]; *L'Ésotérisme comme principe et comme voie*, 1978 [*Esoterism as Principle and as Way*, 1981], *Sur les traces de la religion pérenne*, 1982 [*Echoes of Perennial Wisdom*, 1992], etc.). Schuon, a Swiss established in the United States in 1981, has exerted and is still exerting an influence extending to a very wide audience.

In the wake of Guénon and of Schuon (but certain notable differences separate them) a few personalities stand out. Among them are, in France, Constant Chevillon, an important figure of Martinism and of Freemasonry (*La Tradition universelle*, 1946); Leo Schaya (*La Création en Dieu*, 1983), and the philosopher Georges Vallin (*La Perspective métaphysique*, 1977). We also find Catholics nevertheless very close to Guénonian thought (Louis Charbonneau-Lassay, *Le Bestiaire du Christ*, 1940 [*The Bestiary of Christ*]), and Jean Borella, *Esotérisme guénonien et mystère chrétien*, 1998 [*Guénonian Esoterism and Christian Mystery*]).

In Italy, Julius Evola's (section I, 1) work has been the subject of a great many commentaries since the early 1990s. In England, it was Martin Lings (*The Eleventh Hour*, 1987), who was Guénon's personal secretary. In the United States, we find the academics Ananda K. Coomaraswamy (1877–1947), prolific author of writings on various religions, Seyyed Hosseyn Nasr (*The Encounter of Man and Nature*, 1968; *Knowledge and the Sacred*, 1981; section I, 3), Huston Smith (*The Religions of Man*, 1958; *Forgotten Truth*, 1976; *Beyond the Post-Modern Mind*, 1982), and James Cutsinger, author of many articles since the 1980s and one of the principal commentators of Schuonian thought. The differences of orientation among these perennialists go beyond the scope of this short presentation (e.g., considerations on Nature feature prominently in Nasr's philosophy). Many journals, associations, and study centers also represent this current.

3. Initiatic Societies

Among the masonic Rites already mentioned, Rectified Scottish Rite, Ancient and Accepted Scottish Rite, and Memphis-Misraïm have survived since World War I. In the paramasonic domain properly speaking, Martinism has fragmented into several Orders with a complex history and in which, depending on the branch, the ritual of the times of Papus, and even the theurgical rite of the Élus Coëns are still practiced. The Brethern of the Societas Rosicruciana in Anglia (SRIA), limited, as we have seen ([chapters 4](#), section III, 1), to regular masons, pursue an initiatic work of a neo-Rosicrucian type behind

the discreet cover of their Lodges or so-called “Colleges.” Issued from the SRIA, the Golden Dawn (GD) disappeared at the beginning of the century, at least in its original form. The Order of the Builders of the Adytum founded by Paul Foster Case constitutes a sort of extension of it; Hermeticism, Kabbalah, and Tarot are part of its subjects of study. The Ordo Templi Orientis ([chapter 4](#), section III, 1) developed greatly, especially in the United States, with an important center in California.

The symbol of the rose and the cross has been, in the twentieth century, the object of considerable interest, which broadly exceeded the boundaries of paramasonry. Created in 1915 by Harvey Spencer Lewis, the Antiquus Mysticus Ordo Rosae Crucis already counted a few hundred thousand members at the death of its founder. Quantitatively, it is, after the TS, the second most important movement in the history of Western esotericism proper. Open to the outer world and to modernity, it provides its members with a culture (many lectures, site visits, libraries, etc.) as well as with an initiatic way. Its headquarters, originally located in the great “Amorcian” center of San José, California, moved to Omonville in France in 1990. Very different is the Lectorium Rosicrucianum (or International School of the Golden Rosycross), founded in Haarlem, the Netherlands, in 1924 by Jan van Rijckenborgh (*alias* Jan Leene) and of which an important center is located in Ussatles-Bains, France. Its teaching is of a Gnostic (in the sense of ancient Gnosticism) and Cathar type, rather difficult to blend with traditional Rosicrucianism (of the seventeenth century); this is, however, what the thinkers of the Lectorium have been attempting to do. Among the many neo-Rosicrucian Orders, let us further mention the *Fraternità Terapeutica Magica di Myriam*, in Italy, created by Ciro Formisano (*alias* Giuliano Kremmerz; his *Corpus Philosophorum totius Magiae* was published in 1988–1989). This Order has a partly therapeutic vocation. It combines Rosicrucianism with egyptophilia and, since its founder's death, has enjoyed a certain success. This list of so-called Rosicrucian Orders is not exhaustive (the most complete listing is found in the book by Massimo Introvigne, *Il Cappello del Mago*, 1990).

The Anthroposophical Society ([chapter 4](#), section II, 3), which became Allgemeine Anthroposophische Gesellschaft in 1923, has maintained an intense activity undiminished by the death of its founder, Rudolf Steiner. Dornach has remained, as before, a high place of culture and a center whose influence was favored by the success of Steiner schools for children (the first “Freie Waldorfschule” was created in Stuttgart in 1919). The same goes for the TS, whose centers remain very active in the countries where it has taken hold. Its branches, however, are varied, and some of them separated from it to constitute original organizations. One example is the Loge Mystique Chrétienne (LMC; close in spirit to Anna Kingsford, cf. [chapter 4](#), section II, 2), founded in 1923 by the psychoanalyst Violet Mary Firth (*alias* Dion Fortune, who came from the GD); this LMC became in 1928 the Society of the Inner Light, which practiced various forms of evocatory magic.

In addition to these formally constituted associations are various forms of “Fraternities,” “Fellowships,” and esoteric study groups. Thus, Gurdjieff (section I, 3), established in France in 1922, founded his “Priory” in Avon and in 1933 settled definitively in Paris. In 1915, he met Ouspensky (section I, 3), to whom we owe a detailed relation of the master's words as well as the “work” practiced in the “Gurdjieff groups.” This “work” rests on a sort of pedagogy of “awakening” (cf. *In Search of the Miraculous: Fragments of an Unknown Teaching*, 1949; section I, 3). Gurdjieff groups still operate in various countries.

The very eclectic Universal Great Brotherhood of Serge Raynaud de la Ferrière, begun in 1947, active especially in Central and South America, combines purportedly “pre-Columbian” teachings with speculations on the Age of Aquarius. It is a popular movement, like the New Acropolis (NA), founded in the 1950s by the Argentinian Angel Livraga. Established in many countries, in France by Fernand Schwartz, the NA provides courses and publishes periodicals about the various religious traditions of humanity, notably their artistic aspects. In 1952, the Colombian Samael Aun Weor founded a Gnostic Association of Anthropological and Cultural Studies, it too very eclectic, which mixes Buddhism, Tantrism, Steinerian anthroposophy, sexual alchemy, and the teachings of Gurdjieff. Let us finally mention the Atlantis Association and the journal by the same name, founded in 1927 by Paul Le Cour—one of the first in France to launch the idea of an Age of Aquarius. It is characterized by a Christian esotericism of an eclectic bent in which, as its name indicates, the myth of Atlantis holds an important place.

4. “Tradition”: A Multifaceted Notion

To the various associations just discussed, we could add a few more, most of which would rather belong to what is called the New Religious Movements (NMR). The NMR represents a phenomenon that began to manifest itself in the 1960s. Many are those whose teaching contains elements of an esoteric type in the sense that we understand it (e.g., the Universal White Brotherhood of Peter Konstantinov Deunov and Mikhaël Omraam Aïvanhov). The same goes for the literature of the New Age, which to a certain extent feeds on such elements. New Age is the general term for a diffuse movement that has prospered from its beginnings in California in the 1970s, and one of whose origins goes back partly to Alice Bailey. This founder of the Arcane School in 1923 is also the author of many works of occultist content. The supporters of the New Age proclaim the coming of a new era, the Age of Aquarius, characterized by a progress of humanity placed under the sign of a rediscovered harmony and of an “enlarged (extended) consciousness.”

Part of the panoply of the New Age is the practice of “channeling.” This consists in letting speak, through a medium, entities from the beyond, who, unlike what is supposed to happen in Spiritualism, are not deceased persons. One of the first examples of channeling is that (in the 1930s, in Zurich) of messages coming from an entity giving itself the name Atma. The entity expressed itself during séances organized for this purpose (and in which Carl Gustav Jung happened to take part), through the voice of a “sleeping” (nonmagneticized) subject, Oscar Rudolf Schlag, a person well learned in terms of esoteric currents. The speeches of Atma, published in several volumes (*Die Lehren des A.*, 1995–2010), contain a wealth of passages in an oracular style on alchemy, the tarot, magic, arithmology, mythology, and Hindu traditions (on yoga, notably) as well. More recently, channeling has been part of the panoply of the New Age.

On the shores of this oceanic landscape constituted by the New Age and the NRM, the esoteric currents properly speaking lose their outlines. They also dissolve into what is called the Cultic Milieu (a felicitous expression introduced by Colin Campbell in 1972), which consists, for example, of “occultist fairs.” These are actual market-places, such as the Kohoutek Celebration of Consciousness in San Francisco in January 1974, an improbable jumble where all the imaginable fringe sciences were on display in stands and booths. This was only one of the first major manifestations of this type, in a long series that is ongoing. What is essential here, on the one hand, seems to be the need for “transformation” motivating the participants, and, on the other hand, the opportunity to discover their good grain under the chaff for those who want to sift through it.

The world of publishing provides group fairs of another type. The year 1960 saw the publication in France of a book typical in this regard, signed by Louis Pauwels and Jacques Bergier (*Le Matin des magiciens*. [*The Morning of the Magicians*, 1963]), which quickly appeared in several languages. In this skillful commercial enterprise, whose success was extended by the magazine *Planète* (1961–1968), the metaphysical and religious mysteries are presented as scientific enigmas, and vice versa.

III. Arts and Humanities

1. Arts and Literature

The prose and poetry of Oscar Vadislav Milosz (*Ars Magna*, 1924; *Les Arcanes*, 1927) are the work of an “initiate” and a great artist. The Russian Alexander Blok (“The Rose and the Cross,” 1915) is close to him in many ways. In the work of the Portuguese Fernando Pessoa, elements borrowed from the esoteric currents often mold his poetry and short prose pieces (thus, *A Hora do Diabolo*, 1931–1932). The Surrealists (André Breton, *Arcane 17*, 1947; *L'Art magique*, 1957) drew from the corpus of the “occult

sciences.” However, personal involvement is more explicit among the young authors of the movement called “Le Grand Jeu” and the journal by the same name (1928–1931), which in the 1920s flourished around René Daumal (cf. his book *Le Mont Analogue*, 1952, posthumous edition [*Mount Analogue*, 2004]). They drew part of their inspiration from the said currents.

This involvement is also explicit in a number of works of fiction. Thus in the novels of Gustav Meyrink (*Der Golem*, 1915; *Das Grüne Gesicht*, 1916, etc.) and of Mircea Eliade (*infra*, 2; his novel *Viata noua*, 1941; his short story *The Secret of Dr. Honigberger* [1940] was published in 1999). Eliade was not only a famous historian of religions but also a novelist. Personal commitment is less conspicuous in Hermann Hesse's *Das Glasperlenspiel*, 1943 (*The Glass Bead Game*, 1970). The English-speaking world is especially rich in “fantastic” works of fiction: the novels of Charles Williams (*War in Heaven*, 1930; *The Greater Trumps*, 1933) and those of Dion Fortune (*The Secrets of Dr. Traverneer*, 1926) also indeed belong to the esoteric currents. Later, the Frenchman Raymond Abellio (section I, 1, 3) attempted to communicate the essence of his *gnosis* in his own novels (e.g., *Les Yeux d'Ézéchiél sont ouverts*, 1949; *La Fosse de Babel*, 1962).

Dan Brown's *The Da Vinci Code* (2003) well reflects the interest of a broad public inclined toward the “conspiracy theories” so popular today, whereas Umberto Eco's *Il Pendolo di Foucault* (1988), which parodies these famous “theories” in a mischievous fashion, is not meant to deliver any message whatsoever. In this mischievous genre, spiced with a touch of the picaresque, also appeared works of fiction by Frederick Tristan, for example, *Les Tribulations héroïques de Balthasar Kober* (1980).

In the plastic arts, the very figurative paintings in the last manner of the Portuguese painter Lima de Freitas suggest possible connections with Surrealism. However, they are actually very distinct from this current by their elaborately developed neo-Pythagoreanism and their explicit references to esoteric themes, for example, to seventeenth-century Rosicrucianism (“Calmo na falsa morte,” 1985; “O Jardim dos Hespérides,” 1986; etc.). The influence of the TS proved deep and lasting (cf. the fine retrospective *The Spiritual in Art: Abstract Painting, 1890–1985*, 1986, and *Okkultismus und Avantgarde. Von Munch bis Mondrian, 1900–1915*, 1995). In the work of the German Joseph Anton Schneiderfranken (*alias* Bô-Yin-Râ), a poet and spiritual master, painting and writing draw their inspiration from an orientalizing esotericism (*Das Buch der Gespräche*, 1920) [*The Book of Dialogues*]. In architecture, let us recall that the Goetheanum ([chapter 4](#), section III, 3), at Dornach, near Basle, designed by Rudolf Steiner, was reconstructed after the fire of 1922 and that its stainedglass windows reflect a very “anthroposophical” symbolism.

Among the many Tarot decks of the century, several demonstrate an attempt toward figurative renewal in the tradition of fin de siècle occultism. Thus, “Cartomancia Lusso”; “Rider-Waite Tarot” (1909) of

Pamela Coleman Smith; “Thot Tarot,” toward 1940, of Frieda Harris, inspired by *The Book of Thoth*, 1944 of Aleister Crowley (section I, 1; [chapter 4](#), section III, 1)—a deck that has become one of the most famous Tarots in the world. The art, also very figurative, of the color plates and illustrations for Anglo-Saxon books where Art Nouveau and neo-Romanticism are combined in an original fashion, features a specific genre that deserves study (thus, the large infolio volume by Manly Palmer Hall, *The Secret Teachings of all Ages*, 1928).

It would be difficult to discuss musical esotericism other than with respect to the theories expounded by composers (but when such theories exist, we can expect to find their traces in the scores). Examples are Cyril Scott (*The Influence of Music*, 1933) or Karlheinz Stockhausen (*Texte zur Musik*, 1970–1977). For the same reason, there would be little to say about cinema, which makes use of themes or of motifs that, although present in the esoteric currents, are not unique to them (cf. introduction, sections I and IV). On the other hand, the seventh art lends itself admirably to the genre of fantasy as well as to the fantastic. However, cinema sometimes resorts to explicit references to certain characters or traditions—thus, *Meetings with Remarkable Men*, by Peter Brook (1978), more especially because this feature draws inspiration from Gurdjieff.

2. Psychology and the Humanities

The thought of Sigmund Freud has deep roots in the romantic *Naturphilosophie* that discovered the existence of the unconscious ([chapter 4](#), I, 1), but it goes to the psychologist Herbert Silberer to have been the first to suggest a psychoanalytical reading of the alchemical texts (*Probleme der Mystik und ihrer Symbolik*, 1914). It is, however, to Carl Gustav Jung (1875–1961) that is due the title of great explorer of some of the “psychological” riches of part of the modern Western alchemical corpus. He wanted to demonstrate (*Psychologie und Alchemie*, 1936–1952; *Mysterium Coniunctionis*, 1955–1956; etc.) that “transmutation” and the symbolism of the stages of its journey correspond to a highly positive work of the psyche in search of its own edification or harmonization, of its “individuation.” With this in mind, he selected from this corpus the titles the most likely to support his demonstrations, and in making this choice he underwent the influence of the representatives of Occultism—a current from which he was not very distant chronologically and with which he was well familiar. Now, Jung had tended to present alchemy as a whole as a sort of spiritual technique (cf. e.g., M. A. Atwood, in [chapter 4](#), section I, 4), thereby underplaying the properly “scientific” aim of most of the alchemists (cf. [chapter 2](#), section III, 2). Thus, he contributed to give a partial idea of the history of alchemy—but in stimulating public interest in this genre of literature, he simultaneously contributed to “repatriate” it into our culture.

Some philosophers have pursued a rather similar direction, by introducing the Western esoteric corpus into the field of their reflections. This pursuit can lead philosophy back to its vocation of a spiritual exigency, indeed of a transmutative practice of being (as in Françoise Bonardel, *Philosophie de l'alchimie. Grand Oeuvre et modernité*, 1993). Alternatively, it can open the classical logics to new approaches (thus Jean-Jacques Wunenberger, *La Raison contradictoire*, 1990). It can place the esoteric *imaginaire* in the perspective of a so-called “traditional” anthropology (Gilbert Durand, *Sciences de l'Homme et Tradition*, 1975). Again, it can marry metaphysics, esotericism, and psychology (Robert J. W. Evans, *Imaginal Body*, 1982; *The New Gnosis*, 1984).

Indeed, embedded in a universe considered bereft of consciousness and in a human community henceforth lacking any ideologies or even ideals, modern men and women often feel as though they are confronted with themselves in isolation. They are therefore easily tempted to see in certain elements of Western esotericism an approach to self-knowledge, which would not depend on previous adherence to a system of beliefs or of ethics, but which, they think, might be capable of conferring meaning on their life and on the universe. The *Oratio* of Pico della Mirandola on the “dignity of the human being” ([chapter 2](#), section I, 3) has thus become topical once again, in the sense that it would be our responsibility always to redefine ourselves, to find or to rediscover our place in Nature and within a universal society and culture.

If this tendency does indeed lie within the spirit of the New Age, it nevertheless goes beyond it, by taking the form of a hitherto unparalleled interest in psychology. Since the mid-twentieth century, we have been experiencing a “psychological” epoch (i.e., one in which people are keenly interested in various forms of psychological techniques). Elements of Western esotericism thus penetrate, accompanied by borrowings from various Eastern “wisdoms,” into the general public through the channel of therapies, whence the success of a Carl Gustav Jung—or of a John G. Bennett (*Gurdjieff: Meeting a New World*, 1973). Bennett could transpose into clear language the abstruse statements of Gurdjieff, whose teachings also belong, after all, to a form of therapy. Whence also, outside the “psychological” field, we witness the success of a Mircea Eliade (*supra*, 1), historian of religions whose work responds well to a double demand for culture and universality, and who strove to show that the “sacred” is a constitutive element of human nature. This idea is debatable, certainly, but it incited him to prospect the history of the religious traditions of the world, including—although in a rather limited scope—that of the esoteric currents in the West (*A History of Religious Ideas*, 1976–1983; *Occultism, Witchcraft, and Cultural Fashion*, 1976).

3. Historiography of Western Esotericism

As stated in the introduction (sections III and IV), it is appropriate to distinguish two categories of historians; on the one hand, the “generalists”; on the other hand, those who confine themselves to the study of specific authors or currents. Of course, some are both at once.

For a list of those representatives of the first category who strive to refine the methods of approaching the specialty considered as such, we simply refer to the introduction. Let us cite here some other “generalists,” whose main purpose is nevertheless not especially in the order of methodology proper. Karl R. H. Frick, author of *Licht und Finsternis* and *Die Erleuchteten* (1973–1978), has been dealing especially with esoteric societies. James Webb (*The Occult Underground*, 1974; *The Occult Establishment*, 1976) has clarified various aspects of the occultist current and its repercussions over the past about one hundred and fifty years. J. Gordon Melton has edited a useful encyclopedia (*Occultism and Parapsychology*, 2001). Massimo Introvigne (a specialist, as is Melton, of the NRM) has given the best study of all the “magical” (in the broad sense) currents and societies of the West having existed since the middle of the nineteenth century (*Il Cappello del Mago*, 1990). Finally yet importantly, Joscelyn Godwin continues to pursue a variety of researches. Professor of musicology, Godwin is the author of *Harmonies of Heaven and Earth* (1987), *L'Ésotérisme musical en France* (1991), and so on, and in addition has to his credit a wide range of publications on many authors—on Robert Fludd, Athanasius Kircher, “fin de siècle” esotericism, and the like (cf. notably his important work *The Theosophical Enlightenment*, 1994).

As recalled above, the second category includes (here again, since the mid-twentieth century) historians whose works pertain to one or several authors. Its representatives are too numerous to be the object of a list, even a succinct one; but attention is called to the first lines of the bibliography presented in this volume, which refers to a bibliography both general and particular.

Let us add in closing that students of “Western esotericism” are aided in their research by the existence of some specialized and richly documented periodicals. Their titles appear *infra*, in the *addenda* of the bibliography. Also included in these *addenda* are the names of the best libraries dedicated to this same specialty.

1. All the works cited here were published in English by Sophia Perennis in 2004/2005.